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Personal Writings
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What is Friendship?

What is a friend? Who should be called...a friend...a brother...a sister...a mentor? This question, seemingly simple and easy, is so packed and bundled, that it has taken a millennia to find that friends are fleeting, important, and rare. Many believe they understand, many say they have “friends,” but many...many of these same people are hopeless, depressed, and alone. You see, friendship is not just knowing someone, or hanging around them; it's deeper, it's sacrificial, it's sacred. There are three main true friendships I see, the first and more secure is that with the Lord, this friendship or relationship will last, its sacred, its secure. The second is that with a spouse, while not everyone gets the privilege of this, it's conventional, and sacred, but second to the friendship of the Lord. The third is with those brothers or sisters in Christ who are truly friends, but you're asking; “what then is a friend?” Simple put, as Aristotle once said, a true friendship, that of virtue is: “Perfect friendship is the friendship of men who are good, and alike in virtue; for these wish well alike to each other qua good, and they are good themselves. Now those who wish well to their friends for their sake are most truly friends.”¹

To understand what Aristotle said above, you must first understand what friendship is not. This brings in Aristotle's four types of friendships. They are as follows: friendship of vice, friendship of utility, friendship of pleasure, and friendship of virtue. I want to begin by defining my terms. Here I am defining a “friend” as someone you hang around, know, and/or like. A “true friendship”—best friends, you could say—is that of a friendship of virtue.

¹ Aristotle. “Nicomachean Ethics.” Translated by D. P. Chase. In *The Philosophers: Old Western Culture*, vol. 4, edited by Daniel Foucachon and Wesley J. Callihan (Moscow, ID: Roman Roads Media, 2017), 455.

First, friendship of vice, the easiest to understand, but can be hardest to spot and the most dangerous to experience. A friendship of this nature is, as it states, of vice or of non-virtue. As Aristotle says: “But wicked men have no steadfastness (for they do not remain even like to themselves), but become friends for a short time because they delight in each other's wickedness.”² This type of friendship is short-lived, and in reality not a friendship at all, as rather than being friends on some sense of virtuous matter, you are “friends” on a matter of vice—sin—which is degrading and fleeting. It's a selfish love of oneself over the love for the other. While it may feel real, and appear to be so, it's not; it's a facade, a wolf in sheep's clothing waiting to attack when you turn your back.

Second, friendship of utility—also known as transactional—this type of friendship is for the love of something you gain from each other. “Now those who love each other for their utility do not love each other for themselves but in virtue of some good which they get from each other.”³ A good example is that between you and your employer, you are “friends” in the sense of you both get something from each other, you work for your boss, giving him labor, and in return he pays you for your work. As soon as one of those stops being true, the love for the good the other provides ceases. There are many other examples, but the thing to keep in mind is this idea of a transaction, I get something from him and he gets something from me.

Third, friendship of pleasure, this type of friendship is similar to that of utility, but rather than getting something—maybe an item or other good—from each other, you get some sense of pleasure—maybe an action or enjoyment. Again to the one before it only lasts as long as this transaction continues, once it disappears, so does the love for the other. “Such friendships, then,

² Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics*, 462.

³ Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics*, 454.

are easily dissolved, if the parties do not remain like themselves; for if the one party is no longer pleasant or useful the other ceases to love him.”⁴

Fourth, friendship of virtue—I will warn you now, this will be the longest section; there is so much to unpack. A friendship of virtue explained simply, a friendship where your love for the other surpasses the love for oneself in the matter of the friendship, through your general love for their well-being for their sake, not your own.

Perfect friendship is the friendship of men who are good, and alike in virtue; for these wish well alike to each other qua good, and they are good themselves. Now those who wish well to their friends for their sake are most truly friends; for they do this by reason of own nature and not incidentally; therefore their friendship lasts as long as they are good—and goodness is an enduring thing. And each is good without qualification and to his friend, for the good are both good without qualification and useful to each other. So too they are pleasant; for the good are pleasant both without qualification and to each other, since to each his own activities and others like them are pleasurable, and the actions of the good are the same or like. And such a friendship is as might be expected permanent, since there meet in it all the qualities that friends should have.⁵ (Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics*, ch. 8).

The qualifications for this type of friendship are, to summarize what Aristotle says, to be good in goodness, which is an enduring and almost permanent thing. Aristotle says that this is permanent, and I would agree if it was possible for man in our fallen state to be good in all goodness—perfect—but we are not capable of this. Alas do not be discouraged, because we cannot achieve this sense of perfect friendship, the only difference here is that our earthly friendships can perish, but we are still capable of having them. G. Randolph has a quote I love about this very thing: “Good friends are hard to find, harder to leave, and impossible to forget.”⁶

But if friends are so hard to come by, so often fake, why make friends? Simply put, we were created for communion with not only God, but with one another. As it says in Ecclesiastes:

⁴ Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics*, 462.

⁵ Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics*, 455.

⁶ Quote. Attributed to G. Randolph. In *Goodreads Quotes*, (San Francisco, CA: Goodreads LLC, 2026), <https://goodreads.com>.

Two are better than one, because they have a good reward for their toil. For if they fall, one will lift up his fellow. But woe to him who is alone when he falls and has not another to lift him up! Again, if two lie together, they keep warm, but how can one keep warm alone? And though a man might prevail against one who is alone, two will withstand him—a threefold cord is not quickly broken.⁷

Those we hang around, those we are friends with help us, sharpen us, and guide us. A man alone is like a single wolf versus a bear, he will surely loss, but a wolf with his pack, well he has a much better chance of winning. The only thing to remember is who your surround yourself with, as who you hang around effects you much. You sharpen each other, for good or for bad, remember what Denzel Washington once said in a speech:

If you hang around 5 confident people, you will be the 6th. If you hang around with 5 intelligent people, you will be the 6th. If you hang around with 5 millionaires, you will be the 6th. If you hang around with 5 idiots, you will be the 6th.⁸

Friends are good and holy, we were designed to be in communion with one another and to surround ourselves with people to build us up and to in return build them up. We must only be weary of who those are. There will always be wolves in sheeps clothing and we must learn to spot them. This was long I know, but important, to understand who your friends are is a skill so valuable it will save you much heartache in life. Feel free to share this, I am not gatekeeping this, I wrote this to share my thoughts, my meditations, and the ideas of those who came before us. This isn't a secret to be kept, its a truth to be shared far and wide.

⁷ Ecclesiastes 4:9-12 (ESV)

⁸ Quote. Proverbial. In *Facebook*, (Menlo Park, CA: Meta Platforms, 2026), <https://www.facebook.com>.

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